

"How Long Does It Last?" — Volunteer Key

FOOD SAFETY

Eggs

Fresh: up to 6 days at room temperature but usually refrigerated; commercially washed eggs should be refrigerated and discarded if kept too long | **Preserved** (fresh refrigerated vs stored in water glass): stored in water glass (lime water) can last weeks longer, but quality may decline

Wow: Unwashed eggs can be kept safely at room temperature for about 6 days, but commercially washed eggs must be refrigerated and discarded after a shorter time.

Safety: Discard cooked or hard-cooked eggs, egg dishes, and eggs stored improperly; commercial eggs are usually washed and need refrigeration.

Kids: Fresh eggs last some days in the fridge, but special older ways like water glass can keep them longer without fridge.

Tweens: Eggs can last a few days fresh, but if stored in a special lime water called water glass, they last longer, but quality fades.

Teens: Commercial eggs are washed and fragile, but traditional water glass storage can prolong eggs' shelf life though with quality loss.

Adult: The protective bloom on unwashed eggs allows room temp storage up to about 6 days, but commercial washing removes it, requiring refrigeration; water glass storage extends preservation by sealing pores though quality may suffer.

Source: EM 9331 Survival basics food

Butternut Winter Squash

Fresh: 2-3 months stored carefully at 50-55°F and 50-70% humidity | **Preserved** (fresh stored at 50-55°F vs frozen): frozen for 10-12 months maintaining quality

Wow: Hard-shelled winter squashes like butternut can last 2-3 months fresh if stored properly at 50-55°F, much longer than many realize.

Safety: Keep surface dry to prevent decay fungi and do not store near ethylene-producing fruits like apples to avoid early yellowing and spoilage.

Kids: You can keep a butternut squash in a cool, dark place for months before you eat it.

Tweens: Butternut squash stays fresh longest when kept cool and dry at about 50-55 degrees Fahrenheit.

Teens: Proper cool, dry storage lets butternut squash keep quality for several months - freezing extends life even more.

Adult: Winter squash like butternut have a tough rind allowing storage at 50-55°F for months; freezing further extends shelf life but requires proper packaging to maintain quality.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

Green Beans

Fresh: 3-7 days refrigerated | **Preserved** (fresh refrigerated vs pickled (boiling water canned)): at least 1 year shelf stable if processed by boiling water bath canner

Wow: Properly pickled and canned green beans can last a year or more, vastly outlasting the few days fresh green beans last refrigerated.

Safety: Follow exact acid and processing times as insufficient heat or acidity can allow dangerous bacteria growth.

Kids: Fresh beans spoil in a few days but canned ones last a whole year and stay safe to eat.

Tweens: Green beans last only about a week in the fridge, but pickling and canning make them last a year or more.

Teens: Canning with vinegar and processing in a boiling water bath preserves green beans safely for about a year, much longer than fresh.

Adult: Pickling green beans with vinegar and boiling water canning preserves them safely for at least one year by preventing microbial growth and spoilage.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Seafood (Salmon and Crab)

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | **Preserved** (fresh refrigerated vs frozen): up to 3 months frozen at 0°F for quality

Wow: Even though seafood is highly perishable fresh, freezing at 0°F can safely preserve it for up to 3 months while maintaining acceptable quality.

Safety: Freeze seafood quickly and keep at a consistent 0°F; thaw in refrigerator or cold water, cooking immediately afterward.

Kids: Fish goes bad fast but you can freeze it to eat later safely for a few months.

Tweens: Seafood spoils in days fresh but freezing keeps it safe for months if done right.

Teens: Freezing seafood slows spoilage and enzymes, letting it keep quality for a few months versus a couple days fresh.

Adult: Rapid freezing of seafood at 0°F forms small ice crystals limiting cell damage and extending shelf life up to 3 months; thaw properly for safety.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

Lemon Curd

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated after preparation | Preserved (fresh refrigerated vs home canned (water bath)): 3-4 months shelf stable stored cool, dark place home canned

Wow: Home canned lemon curd can last 3-4 months on the shelf, much longer than the 1-2 weeks fresh curd lasts in the fridge.

Safety: Discard lemon curd showing browning or separation; use approved canning processing times based on altitude.

Kids: Fresh lemon curd goes bad quickly but when canned it keeps longer and is safer to eat later.

Tweens: Canning lemon curd makes it last months instead of weeks by sealing it safely.

Teens: Water bath canning lemon curd preserves it for months by killing bacteria and sealing the jar.

Adult: Proper boiling water canning sterilizes lemon curd, producing a vacuum seal that extends shelf life up to 4 months versus short refrigerated life.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

CANNING FRUITS

Fresh Cherries

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): up to 12 months, home canned

Wow: While fresh cherries last less than a week refrigerated, canned cherries can last up to a year safely in the pantry.

Safety: Always check home-canned jars for spoilage signs before use; discard if lids are unsealed or liquid is cloudy.

Kids: When cherries are canned, no bugs can get in and they stay good a long, long time!

Tweens: Canning keeps cherries safe by sealing out air and germs so they don't spoil quickly like fresh ones.

Teens: Canning cherries uses heat to kill microbes and seals the jar, preserving them much longer than fresh.

Adult: Home canning extends cherry shelf life from days refrigerated to a year by creating a vacuum seal and preventing microbial growth.

Source: PNW 736 Fruit pie filling home canning

Strawberry Jam

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Strawberries spoil in just a day or two fresh, but jam canned at home can keep its quality for over a year.

Safety: Store jars in a cool, dark, dry place to maintain quality; discard if lids don't seal or show spoilage.

Kids: Jam keeps strawberries tasty for a long time because it is cooked and sealed tight.

Tweens: Canning jelly heats and seals it, so it stays safe and tasty way longer than fresh strawberries.

Teens: Jam's high sugar and heat processing preserve it by stopping bacteria, extending shelf life greatly.

Adult: The combination of sugar, acidity, and heat in canning inactivates spoilage microbes, extending shelf life well beyond fresh fruit.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

Home Canned Apples

Fresh: 1-3 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Fresh apples can last weeks in the fridge, but canned apples remain safe and good for over a year without refrigeration.

Safety: Use proper home canning methods and store in a cool, dark place; discard any jars showing spoilage.

Kids: Canning apples makes them last a whole year even without a fridge!

Tweens: Canning seals apples tight and cooks them, so they don't spoil like fresh apples do in a few weeks.

Teens: Thermal processing during canning destroys microbes and seals apples, greatly extending shelf life.

Adult: Proper boiling water canning destroys spoilage organisms and creates a vacuum seal that preserves apple quality for a year or more.

Source: SP 50-446 Preserving apples

Canned Peaches

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Peaches go bad in about a week fresh but can keep for over a year when canned properly.

Safety: Always use a tested home canning recipe; discard any jars with unsealed lids or signs of spoilage.

Kids: Peaches in cans last way longer than the fresh fruit you buy at the store.

Tweens: Canning kills germs and keeps peaches safe and tasty for many months longer than fresh.

Teens: The heat processing and vacuum seal in canning peaches prevent spoilage and microbial growth.

Adult: Home canning preserves peaches for a year or more by heat sterilization and vacuum sealing to prevent microbial spoilage.

Source: SP 50-444 Preserving peaches

Fresh Kiwi

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (fresh refrigerated): 10-12 months, home canned jam

Wow: Fresh kiwi can stay good up to two weeks when refrigerated, but canned kiwi jam also lasts nearly a year sealed.

Safety: Store jam jars in a cool, dark place; consume within recommended time for best quality and safety.

Kids: Kiwi jam keeps yummy for a long time after being cooked and put in jars tightly closed.

Tweens: Canning kiwi as jam stops germs and helps keep it fresh and safe many months longer than fresh fruit.

Teens: Heat processing and sugar in kiwi jam preserves the fruit by killing microbes and sealing air out.

Adult: Kiwi jam is preserved by thermal processing and high sugar content, extending shelf life from weeks refrigerated to nearly a year canned.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

CANNING TOMATOES & SALSAS

Fresh Tomatoes

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (fresh refrigerated): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Fresh tomatoes last only a couple weeks in the fridge but home canned tomatoes can stay safely edible for over a year.

Safety: Store home canned tomatoes in a cool, dark place and check seals to ensure safety; discard any jars with signs of spoilage.

Kids: Canned tomatoes last a long time because the heat kills germs and the jar keeps air out.

Tweens: Home canning kills bacteria and seals tomatoes so they stay good much longer than fresh ones in the fridge.

Teens: Canning preserves tomatoes by killing microbes and creating a vacuum seal, extending shelf life well beyond fresh storage.

Adult: Proper heat processing during home canning destroys spoilage organisms and pathogens, and sealed jars prevent recontamination, allowing shelf life of 12+ months.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

Fresh Salsa

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (fresh refrigerated): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Fresh salsa spoils very quickly in the fridge, but when canned properly, salsa can last safely for over a year.

Safety: Use only tested salsa recipes with proper acidification; improper processing can cause spoilage or botulism risk.

Kids: Fresh salsa goes bad fast, but canned salsa is heated and sealed to stay tasty longer.

Tweens: Because fresh salsa has raw ingredients, it spoils quickly; canning cooks and seals it so it lasts a long time.

Teens: Fresh salsa is perishable due to microbes in raw ingredients, while canning uses heat and acid to kill them and prevent spoilage.

Adult: Fresh salsa rapidly deteriorates due to microbial growth; home canning ensures safety by acidifying and heat-processing to eliminate pathogens and seals against contamination.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

Tomato Paste Salsa

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months canned

Wow: Even spicy tomato paste salsas, which seem dense and robust, last only days fresh but up to 18 months canned.

Safety: Always use bottled lemon or lime juice and proper acidification for safe home canning.

Kids: Canned tomato paste salsa lasts much longer because jars are sealed tight after cooking.

Tweens: Heat and sealing in canning make tomato paste salsa safe and long-lasting versus fresh that spoils fast.

Teens: Canning tomato paste salsa uses acid and heat to kill microbes and seal jars, extending shelf life far beyond fresh.

Adult: High acid ingredients and heat processing inhibit microbial growth, enabling safe storage of tomato paste salsa for over a year.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

Fresh Green Salsa (Tomatillo Salsa)

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12 months canned

Wow: Green salsas made from tomatillos spoil fast fresh but can keep up to a full year when canned properly with acid.

Safety: Boiling water processing and acid (bottled lemon juice) needed to prevent spoilage and ensure safety.

Kids: Canned green salsa lasts longer because cooking and sealing keep it fresh.

Tweens: Tomatillo salsa spoils quickly fresh but canning with acid keeps it safe and tasty much longer.

Teens: The acidity and heat treatment in canning preserve tomatillo salsa by killing bacteria and enzymes that cause spoilage.

Adult: Properly acidified tomatillo salsa processed in a boiling water bath eliminates pathogens and stabilizes product for year-long storage.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

Fresh Ripe Tomatoes (unrefrigerated)

Fresh: 3-7 days unrefrigerated | Preserved (fresh unrefrigerated): 12-18 months canned

Wow: Ripe fresh tomatoes left unrefrigerated only last around a week, but canned tomatoes last well beyond a year safely.

Safety: Do not use overripe or frost-damaged tomatoes for canning; product quality and safety may be compromised.

Kids: Tomatoes outside the fridge only stay fresh a little while but canned tomatoes stay good a long time.

Tweens: Fresh tomatoes spoil faster when unrefrigerated; canning preserves them with heat and sealing to last much longer.

Teens: Storing tomatoes unrefrigerated limits shelf life due to mold and spoilage; canning halts these by heat destruction and anaerobic sealing.

Adult: Unrefrigerated ripe tomatoes have short shelf life due to spoilage organisms; canning with tested methods extends edibility safely over a year.

Source: EM 9331 Survival basics food

LOW ACID FOODS

Fresh Mushrooms

Fresh: 3-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Fresh mushrooms last only about a week refrigerated, but pressure canned mushrooms can stay good safely for over a year.

Safety: Mushrooms must be canned using a pressure canner due to low acidity to prevent botulism.

Kids: Canned mushrooms last longer because the heat kills germs that make food go bad.

Tweens: Because mushrooms are low acid, pressure canning uses high heat to keep them safe much longer.

Teens: Pressure canning heats mushrooms enough to kill bacteria that cause spoilage unlike refrigeration which only slows it.

Adult: Low acid mushrooms require pressure canning at 240°F to destroy *Clostridium botulinum* spores, extending shelf life drastically over refrigeration.

Source: SP 50-919 Preserving mushrooms

Potatoes

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated or stored in cool dark | Preserved (frozen): 10-12 months frozen

Wow: Frozen potatoes maintain good quality for nearly a year, far longer than fresh refrigerated potatoes last.

Safety: Freeze at 0°F or below and do not refreeze if thawed above 40°F.

Kids: Frozen potatoes can stay good a really, really long time because the cold stops germs.

Tweens: When frozen, bacteria can't grow on potatoes, so they stay fresh way longer than in the fridge.

Teens: Freezing halts microbial growth and enzyme activity, preserving potato quality much longer than refrigeration.

Adult: Potatoes frozen at or below 0°F can retain quality for 10-12 months by stopping microbial and enzymatic spoilage processes.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

Cooked Meat

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)): 1-2 years, home canned

Wow: Properly pressure canned cooked meat can last up to two years safely, while fresh cooked meat spoils in under a week.

Safety: Fresh cooked meat is highly perishable; pressure canning is critical to prevent botulism in preserved low acid meat.

Kids: Canned meat stays safe longer because the heat kills germs and traps it from air.

Tweens: Pressure canning meat heats it very hot to kill harmful bacteria that grow quickly in fresh cooked meat.

Teens: Canning meat under pressure achieves temperatures lethal to *Clostridium botulinum* spores, unlike refrigeration alone.

Adult: Low acid cooked meats require pressure canning at 240°F to destroy botulism spores, extending safety and shelf life up to two years.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

Fresh Carrots

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 10-12 months frozen

Wow: Frozen carrots maintain quality about a year, far longer than their short refrigerated life.

Safety: Freeze promptly and keep at 0°F for safety and quality; do not refreeze after thawing above 40°F.

Kids: Frozen carrots can last a long time because the cold keeps the bad germs away.

Tweens: Freezing stops germs from growing on carrots, making them stay fresh longer.

Teens: Frozen storage halts enzymatic activity and microbial growth that quickly spoil fresh carrots.

Adult: Freezing carrots at 0°F arrests microbial and enzymatic spoilage, preserving quality for up to a year.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

Fresh Summer Squash

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (pressure canner) or frozen): 12-18 months frozen; 12-18 months pressure canned

Wow: Fresh summer squash spoils in days, but correctly pressure canned or frozen squash keeps for over a year.

Safety: Use pressure canning only; boiling water canners do not safely process low acid squash.

Kids: Canned or frozen squash stays good longer because the bad stuff is killed or stopped by the cold.

Tweens: Squash must be pressure canned to kill germs or frozen super cold to keep fresh for much longer than just in the fridge.

Teens: Freezing and pressure canning squash extends shelf life by stopping microbial growth or killing spores unlike refrigeration.

Adult: Summer squash is low acid and requires pressure canning at 240°F or freezing at 0°F to ensure safety and preserve quality.

Source: SP 50-447 Preserving summer squash

PICKLING

Bread and Butter Pickles

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): up to 1 year, best quality 4 to 5 weeks after processing

Wow: After processing, pickles develop the best flavor only after 4 to 5 weeks but remain safe for up to a year.

Safety: Store jars in a cool, dark, dry place; do not consume if jars unseal during storage.

Kids: Pickles get yummier after a while and can last a long time if kept in the right place.

Tweens: Pickling helps keep the cucumbers safe and tasty for many months when sealed properly.

Teens: The vinegar and salt stop bad germs and let pickles last longer, but flavor improves after weeks.

Adult: Pickling preserves cucumbers through acidity and salt, but optimal flavor needs weeks and quality best within a year.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Summer Squash Relish

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): up to 1 year home canned

Wow: Fresh summer squash lasts only a few days, but pickled squash relish can be shelf-stable for up to a year.

Safety: Use proper canning times and store in a cool, dark place; discard if jars do not seal properly.

Kids: Fresh squash goes bad fast, but pickled squash in jars lasts a long time on the shelf.

Tweens: Pickling changes squash so it stays safe to eat many months without going bad.

Teens: Acidic pickling solutions preserve summer squash safely for up to a year, extending freshness greatly.

Adult: Proper hot-water bath canning acidifies and processes summer squash relish, dramatically extending shelf life.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Pickled Dill Beans

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): up to 1 year home canned

Wow: Fresh green beans spoil quickly, but pickling them with vinegar extends shelf life to a year or more.

Safety: Process jars properly in boiling water canner; store in cool dark place to maintain safety and quality.

Kids: Fresh beans go bad fast, but pickled beans can last a really long time in jars.

Tweens: The vinegar in pickled beans keeps them safe and fresh in jars for many months.

Teens: Pickling provides acidity and heat processing to preserve beans safely up to a year.

Adult: Pickling dill beans combines acidity and heat to inactivate spoilage organisms, ensuring long storage life.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Sweet Gherkin Pickles

Fresh: about 1 week refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): up to 1 year home canned

Wow: Fresh gherkins only last about a week when refrigerated, but pickled versions last safe for a year.

Safety: Store processed jars in cool, dark place; use within one year for best quality.

Kids: Little cucumbers don't stay fresh long, but pickles in jars last lots longer.

Tweens: Pickling helps gherkins stay good and safe to eat for many months.

Teens: Vinegar and sugar in pickling create an environment where bacteria can't grow, preserving them for months.

Adult: Sweet gherkin pickles' acidity and sugar concentration stabilize microbial growth, enabling shelf life near a year.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Pickled Summer Squash

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): up to 1 year home canned

Wow: Fresh summer squash spoils quickly but pickled squash stored properly may last up to a year safely.

Safety: Ensure jars seal properly and store in cool, dark place to prevent spoilage.

Kids: Fresh squash doesn't stay fresh long, but when pickled, it can last much longer in a jar.

Tweens: Pickling changes the squash so it stays good for a long time without going bad.

Teens: Acid in pickling preserves summer squash, but only if canned and stored properly.

Adult: Properly acidified and processed summer squash relishes are microbiologically stable for about one year when stored cool.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

JAMS & JELLIES

Elderberry Jam

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Elderberry jam must have high sugar content to safely prevent botulism when home canned due to its low acidity.

Safety: Use exact sugar ratios as per recipe to ensure safety; do not substitute sweeteners.

Kids: Sugar helps keep the jam safe by stopping bad germs from growing.

Tweens: The sugar in canned elderberry jam stops bacteria and helps it last a long time.

Teens: High sugar lowers moisture, preventing harmful bacteria growth, so canned elderberry jam stays safe long-term.

Adult: The required high sugar ratio reduces water activity, preventing Clostridium botulinum growth in low-acid elderberry jams.

Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries

Concord Grape Jam

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Processed Concord grape jam can safely last over a year at room temperature unlike its fresh grape counterpart.

Safety: Use proper water bath times and jar seals to ensure safe shelf life.

Kids: Canned grape jam is safe and can last a long time because it's cooked and sealed tight.

Tweens: Heating and sealing grape jam stops bad germs so it can stay good in your cupboard for many months.

Teens: The jam gets sterilized and sealed so bacteria can't grow, giving it a much longer shelf life than fresh grapes.

Adult: Thermal processing and sealing create a safe anaerobic environment preventing spoilage and extending shelf life significantly.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

Low Sugar Fruit Spread

Fresh: 3-4 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (refrigerated): Not shelf stable, refrigerated only

Wow: Low sugar fruit spreads cannot be canned safely and must be refrigerated and used quickly.

Safety: Do not can low sugar spreads; store only refrigerated and use within a month.

Kids: Low sugar jam doesn't last long unless you keep it in the fridge.

Tweens: Without much sugar, this spread can spoil faster and needs to be kept cold.

Teens: Low sugar reduces preservation power, so these spreads must be refrigerated and consumed quickly.

Adult: Lacking sufficient sugar reduces water activity, so these spreads require refrigeration and have limited shelf life.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

Uncooked Freezer Jam

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 8-12 months frozen

Wow: Uncooked freezer jams last much longer frozen (up to a year) than refrigerated (just days).

Safety: Keep frozen at 0°F or below; safe beyond best quality period but texture may change.

Kids: Freezing jam keeps it fresh for a very long time.

Tweens: Freezer jams need to be kept frozen to last many months safely.

Teens: Freezing halts spoilage processes, extending freezer jam's shelf life far beyond refrigeration.

Adult: Freezing maintains quality and safety by preventing microbial growth, unlike refrigeration which only slows it.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

Orange Marmalade

Fresh: 7-10 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Orange marmalade safely keeps for over a year canned, but fresh lasts just over a week refrigerated.

Safety: Proper boiling water bath and sealing is essential for safety and shelf life.

Kids: Canned orange marmalade lasts a long time because it's cooked and sealed tight.

Tweens: Heating and sealing preserve orange marmalade much longer than keeping it fresh in the fridge.

Teens: Cooking and sealing produce a safe environment that stops spoilage, extending its shelf life drastically.

Adult: Thermal processing and vacuum sealing inhibit microbial growth and enzymatic activity, preserving it long-term.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

FREEZING & COLD STORAGE

Fresh Apples

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (refrigerated cold storage): 3-6 months refrigerated (32-40°F, 90-95% humidity)

Wow: Fresh apples last only a couple of weeks refrigerated, but properly cold stored apples can keep quality for up to half a year!

Safety: Keep apples in plastic bags or in a refrigerator vegetable drawer to maintain moisture and prevent spoilage.

Kids: Apples rest better in the cold and dark, so they stay crunchy longer!

Tweens: Cold storage slows down how fast apples get old by keeping them at just the right temperature and moisture.

Teens: Keeping apples cold and humid prevents them from ripening and decaying too quickly, extending their freshness.

Adult: Controlled temperature and high humidity reduce respiration and moisture loss in apples, maintaining their quality for months.

Source: *OSU winter crop storage guide*

Carrots

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (refrigerated cold storage): 8-12 months frozen

Wow: Frozen carrots can last nearly a year at 0°F while fresh carrots only last a couple of weeks in the fridge!

Safety: Store frozen carrots at 0°F or below to maintain quality and safety.

Kids: Frozen carrots stay fresh for a very long time because the cold stops them from getting old.

Tweens: Freezing carrots stops bacteria and enzymes that cause spoilage, keeping them good for many months.

Teens: Maintaining 0°F freezing temperature preserves carrots' quality by halting microbial and enzymatic activities longer than refrigeration.

Adult: Freezing to 0°F immobilizes water and slows chemical changes, extending carrot shelf life far beyond refrigeration limits.

Source: *PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables*

Green Peas

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 8-12 months frozen

Wow: Frozen green peas keep peak quality for up to a year while fresh peas spoil within days!

Safety: Store frozen peas at 0°F or lower; refreeze only if still contains ice crystals.

Kids: Freezing peas can keep them for a long time instead of going bad fast.

Tweens: Cold freezing stops the peas from spoiling quickly, so they stay good much longer.

Teens: Frozen storage limits microbial metabolism and enzymatic breakdown, extending pea shelf life.

Adult: Storing peas at 0°F suppresses microbial growth and enzymatic degradation, preserving quality up to a year.

Source: *PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables*

Lamb Roasts/Steaks

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 9 months frozen

Wow: Lamb roasts or steaks can last over 8 months frozen but only a few days fresh before spoiling.

Safety: Freeze quickly in packages no larger than 1-2 pounds for optimal freezing and storage quality.

Kids: Lamb lasts a long time in the freezer but not in the fridge!

Tweens: Freezing lamb preserves its freshness much longer than just keeping it cold in the fridge.

Teens: Maintaining a low freezer temperature prevents spoilage microorganisms, keeping lamb edible far beyond refrigeration.

Adult: Freezing at 0°F inhibits microbial growth and slows enzymatic reactions, extending lamb's shelf life months beyond refrigeration.

Source: *PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home*

Pumpkin / Winter Squash

Fresh: 2-6 months in cool storage at 50-55°F | Preserved (frozen): 8-12 months frozen at 0°F or below

Wow: Some winter squash varieties last several months fresh in cool storage, but freezing them can preserve quality for even longer, up to a year.

Safety: Store squash at 50-55°F with 50-70% relative humidity; freezing preserves quality but not texture and requires blanching before freezing.

Kids: Keeping the pumpkin cool keeps it fresh a long time; freezing it saves it even longer but changes how it feels.

Tweens: Winter squash can last for months in a cool place because it's like a natural storage; freezing helps keep it good for a year but changes texture.

Teens: Winter squash stores well fresh at around 50°F for months due to its tough skin and moisture control; freezing extends life but may alter texture, so blanching first is key.

Adult: Proper curing and cool storage at 50-55°F with moderate humidity prolongs fresh winter squash shelf life for several months;

freezing - after blanching to prevent quality loss - can preserve it for 8-12 months, although texture changes are expected.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

DEHYDRATING & SMOKING

Dried Apples

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (dehydrated): 6-12 months, dried

Wow: Dried apples can last up to a year, far outlasting fresh apples kept refrigerated for just a couple of weeks.

Safety: Store dried fruits in airtight containers in a cool, dark place to maintain quality.

Kids: Drying apples takes out water, so they stay good much longer than fresh apples in the fridge.

Tweens: When apples are dried, the water that causes them to spoil is removed, helping them last many months.

Teens: Dehydration removes moisture, preventing the growth of spoilage organisms and extending shelf life significantly.

Adult: By removing moisture, drying inhibits microbial activity and enzymatic reactions, thus substantially prolonging shelf life compared to fresh apples.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

Home Smoked Fish

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | Preserved (hot smoked): 1-2 weeks refrigerated

Wow: Hot smoking extends refrigerated fish shelf life from just a couple of days to up to two weeks, but only with proper cooking and temperature control.

Safety: Smoked fish must be cooked to at least 150°F internal temperature and stored cold; smoke alone is not a preservative.

Kids: Smoking fish helps it stay good longer, but you still need to keep it cold to be safe.

Tweens: Hot smoking cooks and flavors fish, which helps it last longer in the fridge compared to fresh fish.

Teens: Proper hot smoking cooks fish to safe temperatures and slows spoilage, increasing refrigerated shelf life.

Adult: Hot smoking involves cooking fish to an internal temperature of at least 150°F, which in combination with refrigeration extends shelf life safely beyond that of fresh fish.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

Jerky

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated raw meat | Preserved (dried and cured): 1-2 months room temperature; 3-6 months refrigerated; up to 1 year frozen

Wow: Jerky can last several months unrefrigerated, a massive increase compared to raw meat's couple of days.

Safety: Store jerky in a cool, dark, dry place; check periodically for mold and discard if any is found.

Kids: Jerky is dried meat that keeps much longer than fresh meat because it has no water.

Tweens: Drying jerky removes moisture so bacteria can't grow, letting it last months even without a fridge.

Teens: Jerky's long shelf life results from moisture removal and curing, which inhibit microbial growth and spoilage.

Adult: Properly dried and cured jerky has significantly reduced water activity, preventing microbial proliferation and spoilage over months.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

Dried Carrot

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (dehydrated): 10-12 months dried

Wow: Dried carrots last nearly a year, a stark improvement over fresh carrots' two weeks.

Safety: Store dried carrots in a sealed container away from light and moisture to maintain quality.

Kids: Drying carrots takes away water so they do not rot quickly like fresh carrots.

Tweens: Removing moisture from carrots helps stop them from spoiling for many months.

Teens: Dehydration reduces water activity, preventing microbial growth and thereby extending shelf life drastically.

Adult: Drying carrots lowers available water content, which in turn slows microbial and enzymatic spoilage, allowing long storage.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

Home Cured Bacon

Fresh: 1 week refrigerated fresh pork belly | Preserved (smoked and cured): 2 weeks refrigerated smoked bacon, months frozen

Wow: Smoking and curing bacon extends refrigerated storage from about a week fresh to two weeks and even longer if frozen.

Safety: Cook bacon thoroughly and refrigerate; smoke alone does not ensure safety without temperature control.

Kids: Curing and smoking bacon helps keep it fresh longer but it still needs to stay in the fridge.

Tweens: Smoking and curing slows down bacteria on bacon, making it last longer than fresh pork belly.

Teens: Curing salts and smoking reduce microbes and spoilage, extending shelf life under refrigeration.

Adult: The combined curing and smoking processes reduce microbial load and enzymatic activity, allowing longer refrigerated storage than fresh pork.

Source: *PNW 784 Making bacon at home*